ArabicNLP 2026

The Fourth Arabic Natural Language Processing Conference

Volume 1. Proceedings of the ArabicNLP 2026 Conference

October 28-29, 2026

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Introduction

Welcome to The **Fourth Arabic Natural Language Processing Conference (ArabicNLP 2026)**, co-located with **EMNLP 2026** in Budapest, Hungary. This year's edition is held under the theme Towards Inclusive Arabic NLP,a call for language technologies that serve the full range of Arabic varieties and the full range of their speakers. ArabicNLP 2026 is the eleventh edition of the WANLP/ArabicNLP series, which has developed a growing reputation as a high quality venue for researchers and engineers working on Arabic NLP, where they share and discuss their ongoing work. The first in the WANLP series was held in Doha, Qatar (EMNLP 2014), followed by Beijing, China (ACL 2015), Valencia, Spain (EACL 2017), Florence, Italy (ACL 2019), online with COLING 2020, online with EACL 2021, a hybrid event in Abu Dhabi, UAE (EMNLP 2022), and then in-person events in Singapore with EMNLP 2023, Bangkok, Thailand with ACL 2024, and Suzhou, China with EMNLP 2025Ḟor this year's edition of ArabicNLP, we received a record 193 valid main conference submissions, more than double the 95 received last year. Of these, 164 received at least one review, the remainder having been desk rejected before review for anonymity, formatting or completeness violations, and 139 went through the full review process, in which each paper was read by at least three reviewers and then by one Area Chair, a role newly added to ArabicNLP this year. We accepted 37 papers, for an overall acceptance rate of 22.56% across all submissions that received at least one review. This is the most selective edition to date in the ArabicNLP series.

The accepted papers are presented over the two days of the conference in five oral sessions and two poster sessions: 20 papers as oral presentations and 17 as posters. The oral sessions are organized around the themes that emerged most strongly from the accepted set: Arabic speech, resources and benchmarks; dialects, machine translation and content moderation; Arabic for education and Islamic knowledge; Arabic resources, morphology and syntax; and LLM evaluation, safety and detoxification. Alongside the main conference papers, ArabicNLP 2026 hosts fifteen shared tasks with 212 papers (15 overview papers and 197 system description papers), which appear in Volume 2 of these proceedings.

ArabicNLP 2026 includes an invited talk by **Mona Diab** (Carnegie Mellon University), entitled "**From NLP for Arabic to NLP Through Arabic: What Must AI Understand Before We Trust It to Act?**", a fireside chat, and two panel discussions. We also recognize the strongest contributions through a Best Paper Award and a Best Resource Award, and the review effort behind them through Outstanding Reviewer and Outstanding Area Chair awards, all announced during the conference.

We were able to secure sponsorship funding from different institutions: Google Research, QatarDebate Center (Qatar), Aram Lab (MBZUAI), CAMeL Lab (NYU Abu Dhabi), Tuwaiq Academy (Saudi Arabia), and Resemble AI. We used the sponsorship funds to support student registrations. We thank all our sponsors for their generous support and their help in building up the Arabic NLP community. Finally, we extend our gratitude to everyone who submitted a paper to the conference, and to the Area Chairs and Program Committee members for their diligent efforts in providing reviews within a very tight time frame.

Muhammad Abdul-Mageed

General Chair, on behalf of the conference organizers.

Website of the conference: https://arabicnlp2026.sigarab.org

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Keynote Talk

From NLP for Arabic to NLP Through Arabic What Must AI Understand Before We Trust It to Act?

Dr. Mona Diab
Carnegie Mellon University

Abstract: What does it mean for an AI system to understand a request, recognize an intention, or know when it has misunderstood? These questions reach into the essence of intelligence—and acquire urgency when systems act as autonomous agents. An instruction can be followed literally while its purpose is missed. A fluent answer can conceal uncertainty. Understanding a harmful request perfectly can itself enable harm. This keynote argues that the science of language, meaning, understanding, and interaction should fundamentally reorient NLP's research agenda and inform how we assess AI's capabilities and risks. Arabic offers a particularly productive setting for developing that science. Rich morphology, unwritten vowels, dialect diversity, diglossia, script variation, and code-switching converge within Arabic communicative encounters shaped by social relationships and historical knowledge. I introduce the Arabic Conjunction Hypothesis to investigate how these dimensions jointly shape interpretation and communicative action. Arabic's connections with Persian, Urdu, and Turkic traditions extend the inquiry across languages, scripts, and communities. Arabic's scientific value lies in this productive conjunction, without requiring a claim of exceptionalism. The resulting questions connect directly to debates about alignment and control: whose intentions should a system follow, what evidence supports its interpretation, and when should it ask, defer, challenge, or revise? Understanding is necessary for many forms of trustworthy assistance, but it does not establish benevolent goals or legitimate authority. A science of meaning and interaction can help make those distinctions explicit and testable. Through this lens, annotation, evaluation, and dialogue become instruments for discovering how understanding works. The shift from NLP for Arabic to NLP through Arabic makes Arabic a source of insights that can reshape the field's questions, methods, and foundations. What would we build—and what would we measure—if understanding in interaction became NLP's organizing purpose? Pursuing that question also challenges how we define and evaluate intelligence in AI more broadly. If we fear what AI might do, we must examine what it understands, whose purposes it serves, and what warrants trusting it to act.

Bio: Mona T. Diab is Director of the Language Technologies Institute and a Full Professor in the School of Computer Science at Carnegie Mellon University. An ACL Fellow, she has devoted more than 13 years of her career to Arabic NLP and received the 2023 King Salman Global Academy for Arabic Language prize for advancing Arabic language technologies. She is a founding member of SIGARAB, a former President of SIGDAT and SIGLEX, and a cofounder of the *SEM conference and the CADIM Arabic Dialect Group. Her career spans academia and industry, including leadership roles at Meta and Amazon AWS. Her research connects multilingual NLP, cultural and social dimensions of meaning, and responsible AI. She advocates for a science of language, meaning, and interaction, with Arabic helping shape foundational questions about intelligence, understanding, and trustworthy AI.

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